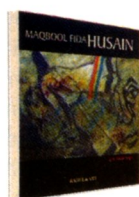


A Legend Untold

M.F. Husain survives another biography that misses all the colours

By S. Kalidas



MAQBOOL FIDA HUSAIN
by K. BIKRAM SINGH
Rahul & Art
Price: Rs 9,999
Pages: 400

Here comes yet another tome on India's most colourful and controversial master of modern art, Maqbool Fida Husain. Tailing a long list of books and publications on the iconic painter—from Richard Bartholomew and Shiv Kapur's *Husain* (Harry N. Abrams 1971, NY) and the artist's own absolutely delightful and riveting autobiography *Husain ki kahani, apni zubani*, (M.F. Husain Foundation

2002) in Urdu and Hindi—as this new book does, one can wonder what more could be said about a life and an art that has been constantly fuelling media headlines and private gossip for over three decades now.

Perhaps, one can presume, the point would lie in the telling of the story. After all, the Ramayana has been told and retold a hundred times in several languages and yet each retelling (including Husain's pictorial version) has been a work of high literature. Perhaps there would be an insight here, an opinion there, that would capture the contemporary reader's imagination or throw a sudden beam of light on some hitherto unremarked facet of the artist's life or works. Perhaps, the language and the structure of the book would set some new standards in the genre of artist's biography or art criticism.

However, right from its dull and drab cover picture, the book makes for heavy plowing—both metaphorically and literally. Always sincere and ever humble in his approach, K. Bikram Singh has trudged the much-

trodden landscape of Husain's legend like a plodding pilgrim, diligently acknowledging all his predecessors and sources. He laboriously retraces all that one has already read about Husain, without sparing much thought or effort to the colour or texture of an anecdote well told. His painfully long-winded commentaries on individual paintings, stylistics, socio-cultural history and sources of Husain's inspiration like Urdu poetry, women et al are turgid to say the least.

Besides, coming as it does well after the landmark judgement of the Delhi High Court (which has subsequently been upheld by the Supreme Court of India), it is surprising that this book fights shy of discussing the notorious obscenity cases filed against the painter directly and cogently. It offers instead, a pseudo-historical thesis on Indira Gandhi's Emergency and rise of the BJP and makes no mention of the outcome of the politics of violence unleashed on Husain that led to his self-imposed exile in London and Dubai. With this act of omission, the writer misses out

on perhaps the only episode in Husain's long and eventful life which earlier biographers could not have covered. And that could well be the greatest failing of this otherwise sincere but insipid account of a momentous life so colourfully and energetically lived.

The 18th-century Urdu poet Meer Taqui Meer has said so well:

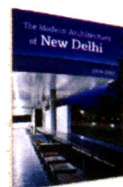
*Rang-e-gul-o-bu-e-gul
hote hain hawa donon/ Ye kya
kaaravan jaata hai, tu bhi jo
jaaye chala* (Colour and
fragrance of a flower are but
like the passing wind/What
caravan is this that passes by,
and what if you too join it)

This heavy book merely joins the long caravan of Husainiana while quite missing the colour and fragrance of his passionately lived life. ■



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